

Hope, expect, and possibility

Teaching guide

Separate what you want from what you think is likely.

Understand the distinction

Hope expresses a desired outcome. Expect expresses a belief about what is likely. May, might, and could express possibility. Will can express a prediction, a decision, or willingness; context matters.

These words are not a fixed percentage scale. I hope it rains does not tell us how likely rain is. I expect a delay can express an unwelcome prediction. Keep facts, wishes, and uncertainty distinct.

Compare the patterns

WISH

I hope the train is on time.

This is the outcome I want.

EXPECTATION

I expect the train to be late.

This is what I think is likely.

POSSIBILITY

The train might be late.

A delay is possible, not certain.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Which expresses a wish: I hope we win / I expect we will win?

A. I hope we win.

B. Both sentences say only what I wish for.

C. I expect we will win.

2. Choose the sentence that expresses possibility: The office will close early.

A. The office must close early.

B. The office might close early.

C. The office definitely will close early.

3. Does I expect a problem mean I want one?

A. Yes. Expect means want.

B. No. It expresses a belief, not a wish.

C. No. It guarantees a problem will occur.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. The forecast is uncertain. Which pair separates a wish from a cautious prediction?

A. I expect the weather is good. It will definitely rain in the afternoon.

B. I hope the weather is good. Rain is guaranteed in the afternoon.

C. I hope the weather is good. It might rain in the afternoon.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. I hope we win.

Hope identifies a desired outcome.

B: Expect adds a prediction or belief, rather than only a wish.

C: Expect reports a belief about what will happen; hope expresses the wish.

2. B. The office might close early.

Might reduces the certainty. May or could also works.

A: Must can express necessity or a strong deduction, not a cautious possibility.

C: Definitely increases certainty. The task asks for possibility.

3. B. No. It expresses a belief, not a wish.

An expectation can be unwelcome.

A: You can expect something you do not want.

C: Expect reports a belief, not a guarantee.

4. C. I hope the weather is good. It might rain in the afternoon.

Hope states a wish; might states a possibility.

A: Expect is a belief, and definitely rain is not a cautious prediction.

B: Guaranteed makes the uncertain forecast sound certain.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-08.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

The forecast is uncertain. Which pair separates a wish from a cautious prediction?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.